# POSC 3710: European Politics

10/7/2026: EUROPEAN PARTY SYSTEMS

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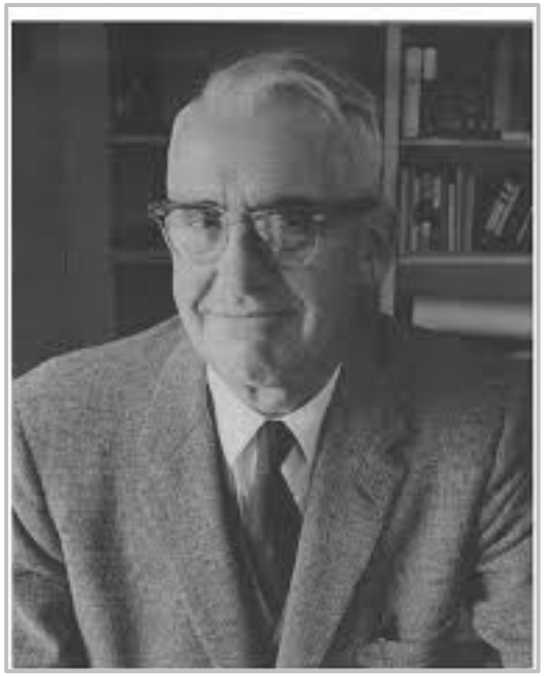
# Final Times of Clemson Poll

- Christian Democrats (26%)
- Social Democrats (24%)
- Populist Right (18%)
- Greens (15%)
- Liberals (12%)
- Radical Left (5%)

- Remember, this is a poll, it may be wrong!

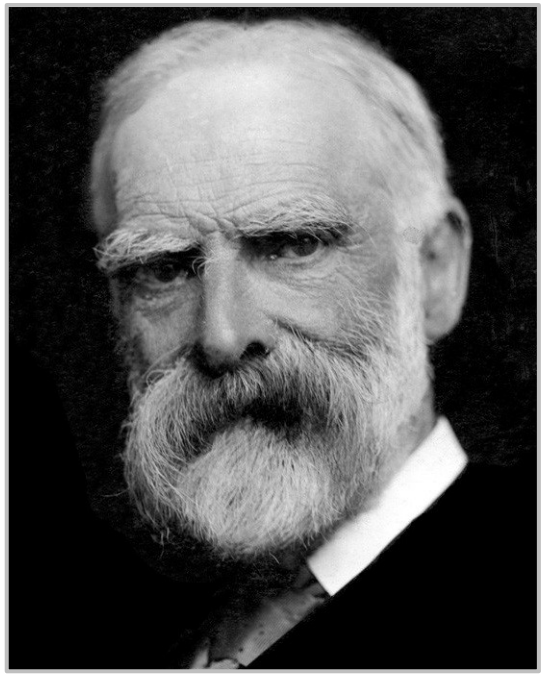
# Where We Left Off

- Before the Midterm: presidents, prime ministers, and how governments can be replaced
- In a parliamentary system, the government is made of parties
  - Even more so than in the US; and the parties have *more* power
- Today: What are parties, exactly? What is a “party system?”



*"The political parties created democracy and … modern democracy is unthinkable save in terms of the parties."*

**E. E. Schattschneider, American political scientist, 1942**



*"Parties are inevitable. No free large country has been without them. No one has shown how representative government could be worked without them."*

**James Bryce, British scholar and ambassador to the United States, 1921**

Today's reading from Katz and Mair asks:

**if "the parties are being fundamentally transformed, what happens to modern democracy?"**

# What Is a Political Party?

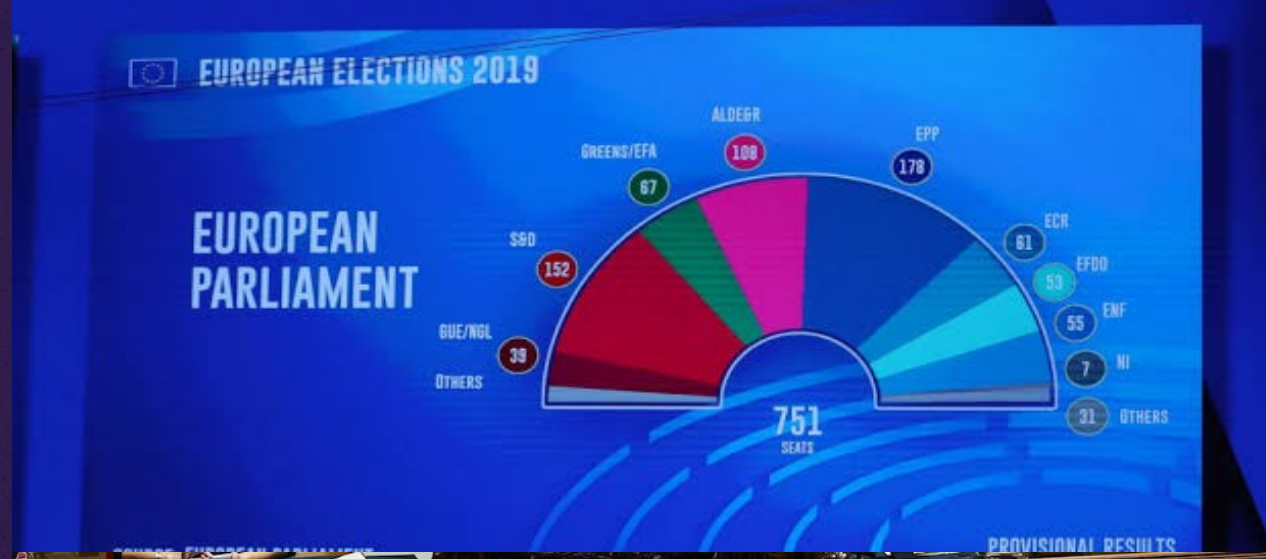


*The Dutch Partij voor de Dieren (Party for Animals) annual congress*

- Anyone want to try to define it?
- A reasonable minimalist definition:
  - “Political parties are organizations that recruit candidates to contest elections in the hope that they can participate in government, or at least push it in the direction of their own ideas.”
- Basically, they are social organizations that seek election
- Many different types, in structure and in ideology
  - Some try to win, some try to get a few seats
  - Some have narrow electoral bases. Others try to appeal to the whole electorate.

# (Why) Do We Need Parties?

- Parties mediate between citizens and the state
  - The state might otherwise act only for those who control it
- Parties structure the political agenda
  - They give voters a menu of choices
- Parties recruit, select and socialize political candidates
- Parties represent socially and culturally significant interests
  - And aggregate them into a coherent bundle
- Parties form governments





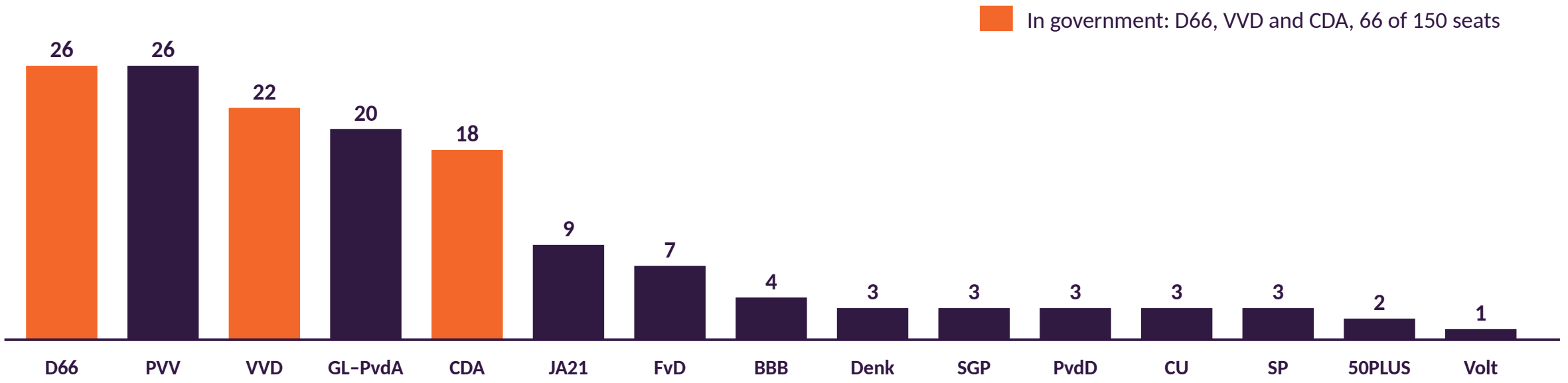

# How many parties won seats in the Dutch parliament in October 2025?

A
**4**

B
**7**

C
**11**

D
**15**




*150 seats, so a majority is 76. The largest party won 26. Prime Minister Rob Jetten of D66 leads a minority government. The United States House has two parties.*

# Party families, roughly from left to right

| | EXAMPLES | IN THE EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT | IN THE FRC |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Radical Left** | Die Linke (Germany), France Unbowed | The Left | Radical Left (RLP) |
| **Social Democratic** | SPD (Germany), Labour (Britain), PSOE (Spain) | Socialists and Democrats | Social Democrats (SD) |
| **Green** | Greens (Germany), GroenLinks (Netherlands) | Greens/EFA | Greens (GP) |
| **Agrarian** | Centre Party (Sweden), Centre Party (Finland) | Mostly Renew Europe | |
| **Liberal** | VVD and D66 (Netherlands), FDP (Germany) | Renew Europe | Liberals (LP) |
| **Christian Democratic** | CDU/CSU (Germany), ÖVP (Austria) | European People's Party | Christian Democrats (CD) |
| **Conservative** | Conservatives (Britain), Republicans (France) | European People's Party; ECR | |
| **Radical Right** | National Rally (France), AfD (Germany) | Patriots for Europe; ECR; ESN | Populist Right (PR) |

*Political scientists group parties into families to compare across countries. Some parties, like regional or single-issue parties, are hard to classify.*

# Four cleavages, frozen into party systems

| | WHO AGAINST WHOM | THE PARTIES IT PRODUCED |
|---|---|---|
| **Center vs. periphery** | The national culture against ethnic, linguistic and religious minorities, often in outlying regions | Regional parties; Belgium's parties, split by language |
| **Church vs. state** | The church defending its historic powers against a growing state | Christian democrats, such as Austria's People's Party |
| **Urban vs. rural** | The traditional landed elite against the new industrial class | Agrarian parties, such as Sweden's Centre Party |
| **Labor vs. capital** | Workers against owners | Social democrats and the other parties of the labor movement |

*Seymour Martin Lipset, an American sociologist, and Stein Rokkan, a Norwegian political scientist, 1967: the party systems of the 1960s still reflected conflicts from the years when the mass franchise arrived.*

# Stable Party Systems (1945–1975)

- After World War II, most European countries had stable party systems
- Usually one large social democratic party on the left, a Christian democratic or conservative party on the right, and sometimes liberals in the middle
- Politics turned mainly on the worker–owner divide, with some religious and regional conflict
- The stagflation of the 1970s and new social movements of the 1980s strained the system

# How parties changed: four kinds of party

## CADRE PARTIES

### 19th century

- Founded by elites to represent elites
- Early conservative and liberal parties

THE MONEY COMES FROM
**the leaders' own wealth and contacts**

## MASS PARTIES

### From the late 1800s

- Represent people who had not held power before
- Often social democratic parties

THE MONEY COMES FROM
**members' dues**

## CATCH-ALL PARTIES

### After 1945

- Reach beyond one class or one church
- Christian democrats; later, social democrats

THE MONEY COMES FROM
**donors of many kinds**

## CARTEL PARTIES

### Since the 1970s

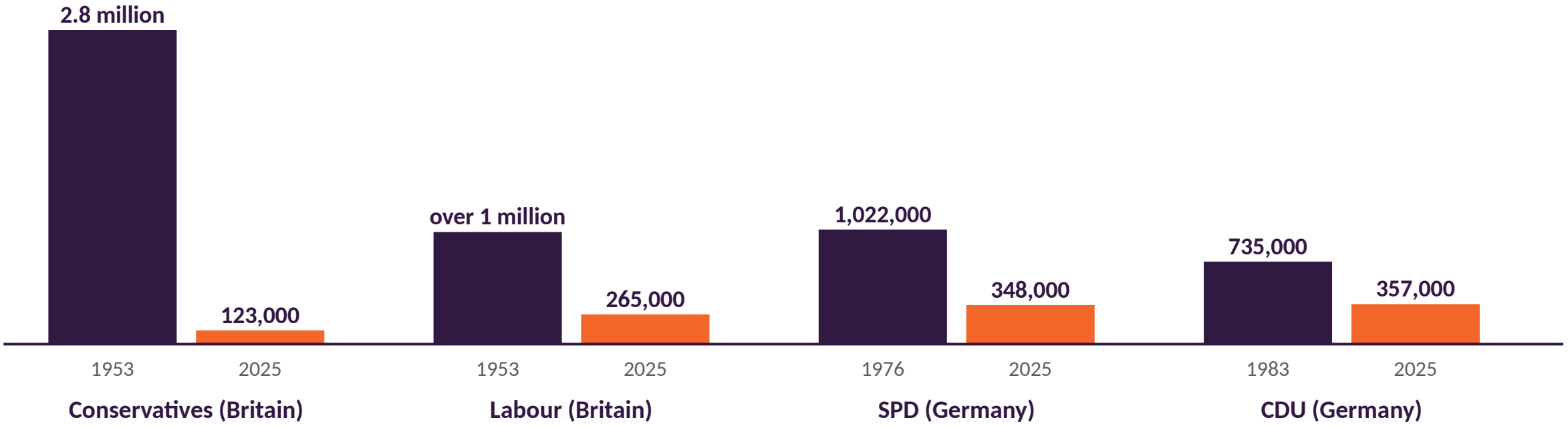
- Collude with their rivals to stay in office
- Contested: critics find little evidence

THE MONEY COMES FROM
**the state**

*Anti-system parties campaign against all of them: the populist left and right, and at first the Greens.*

# In 1953 Britain's Conservative Party reported 2.8 million members. How many does it have now?

| A | B | C | D |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1.4 million | 620,000 | 123,000 | 31,000 |




*Reform UK reported about 268,000 members in December 2025, and the Greens passed 200,000 in March 2026: both more than the Conservatives. The 1950s figures are the parties' own claims and are probably inflated.*

*From today's reading: Katz and Mair*

# The Cartel Party

- Richard Katz (American) and Peter Mair (Irish), political scientists, 1995 and 2009
- Parties "increasingly function like cartels, employing the resources of the state to limit political competition"
- They moved toward the state: public money, party laws, public office
- And away from society: fewer members, weaker loyalties, lower turnout




*Gordon Brown and Tony Blair on New Labour's "business tour" in the 1990s*

# What the cartel does

## LIMITS THE CONTEST

### Fewer questions are put to the voters

- Hard choices are delegated to "independent central banks, courts, or the EU Commission"
- Campaigns turn on who manages better, and on "spectacle, image, and theater"

## SHARES THE MONEY

### The state pays

- State subsidies replace members' dues
- The gap between being in office and out of office shrinks: losing costs less

## KEEPS OUTSIDERS OUT

### Rules that favor insiders

- Funding rules, ballot access and media access that "disadvantage challengers from outside"
- Party activists, who want sharper differences, lose influence

*No conspiracy is required. Katz and Mair: it is "possible to produce the effects of collusion without any illicit communication."*

# Cartel or not?

## PARTY FUNDING, GERMANY

The state pays the parties about €230 million a year, roughly a third of their income. In 2018 the two governing parties raised the cap by €25 million, in a bill passed in ten days.

**Cartel. But the Constitutional Court struck the raise down in 2023, and it makes the state fund any party that wins 0.5%.**

## THE GRAND COALITION

Germany's two big parties, the CDU/CSU and the SPD, campaign against each other. They have governed together for 13 of the last 21 years, and they do today.

**It looks like one. But they won 69% together in 2005 and 45% in 2025: often no other majority exists.**

## THE EUROPEAN CENTRAL BANK

Interest rates for 21 countries are set in Frankfurt by a central bank that no government may instruct and no election can change.

**The reading's own example of an issue taken out of party competition. Defenders say independence is the purpose.**

## THE FIREWALL

Every other party in the Bundestag refuses to govern with the AfD, which won 20.8% in 2025 and leads the polls today.

**The AfD's 2016 program calls the political class "a political cartel." The other parties call the firewall a defense of democracy.**

*Katz and Mair's test: do the parties in office use the state to protect themselves from competition?*

# The Backlash

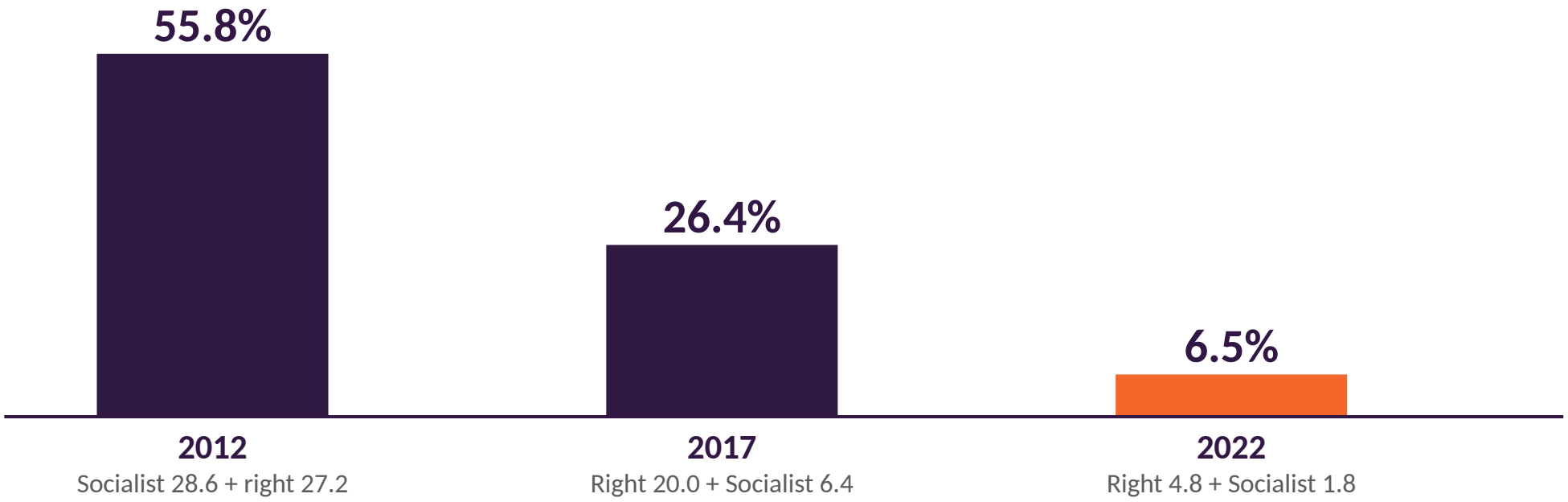



*Nigel Farage, leader of Britain's Reform UK*

- If the big parties look alike, where do voters who want change go?
- Cartelization "has clearly contributed to the rise of populist anti-party-system parties"
- The big parties are "closer to one another … than any one of them is to the voters"
- "The mass party is dead."
- Critics: collusion, or parties chasing the same voters?

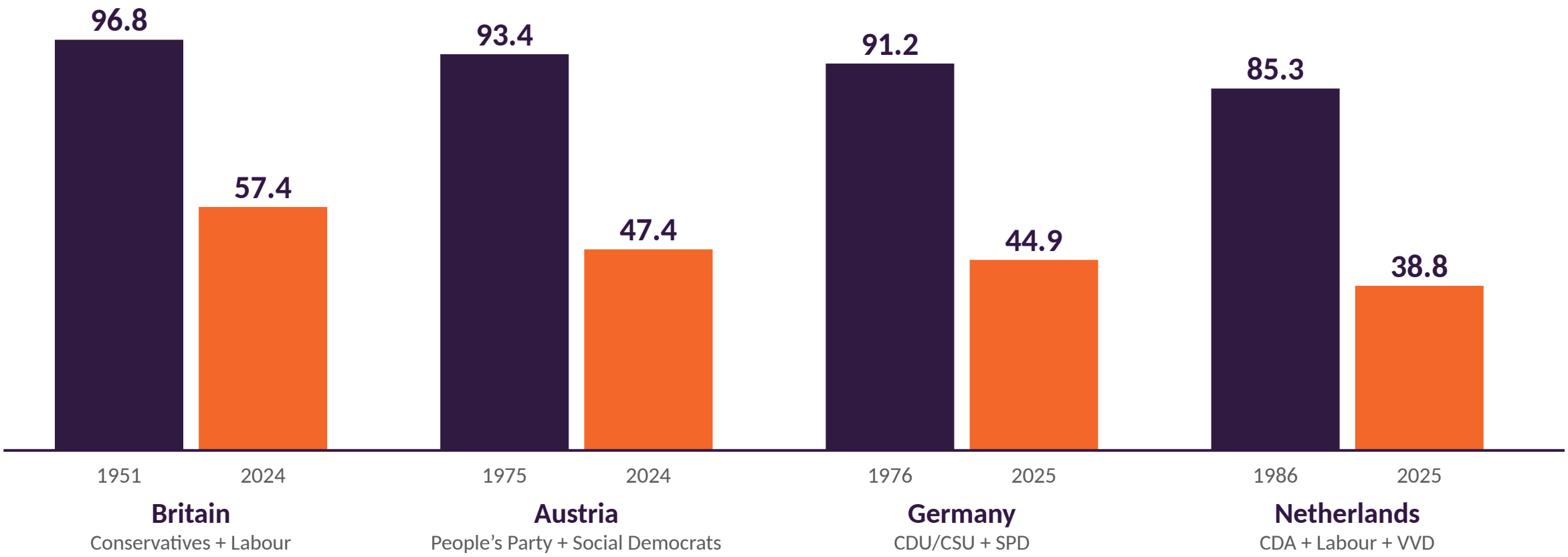
# France, 2012: the Socialist and the mainstream-right candidates for president won 55.8% between them. And in 2022?

| A | B | C | D |
|---|---|---|---|
| 41% | 26% | 16% | 6.5% |




*First round. The top three in 2022: Emmanuel Macron, the president (28%); Marine Le Pen of the National Rally (23%); Jean-Luc Mélenchon of France Unbowed (22%). None came from the two old parties.*

# The big parties' combined share of the vote, then and now




*Percent of the vote in national parliamentary elections. 1976 is West Germany. In 2025 the Dutch Labour Party ran on a joint list with the Greens.*

# Four changes in who the voters are



## EDUCATION

- Graduates are 32% of adults in Western Europe; their share more than doubled from 1992 to 2018
- Graduates lean green and liberal. White school leavers are the radical right's core voters




## MIGRATION

- Migrant-origin communities have grown across Western Europe
- Minority voters have gravitated to center-left parties: in Britain, to Labour




## AGING

- One in ten Western Europeans was 65 or older in 1967; nearly one in five is now
- Older voters turn out more, but age is "not yet being mobilized" as a divide

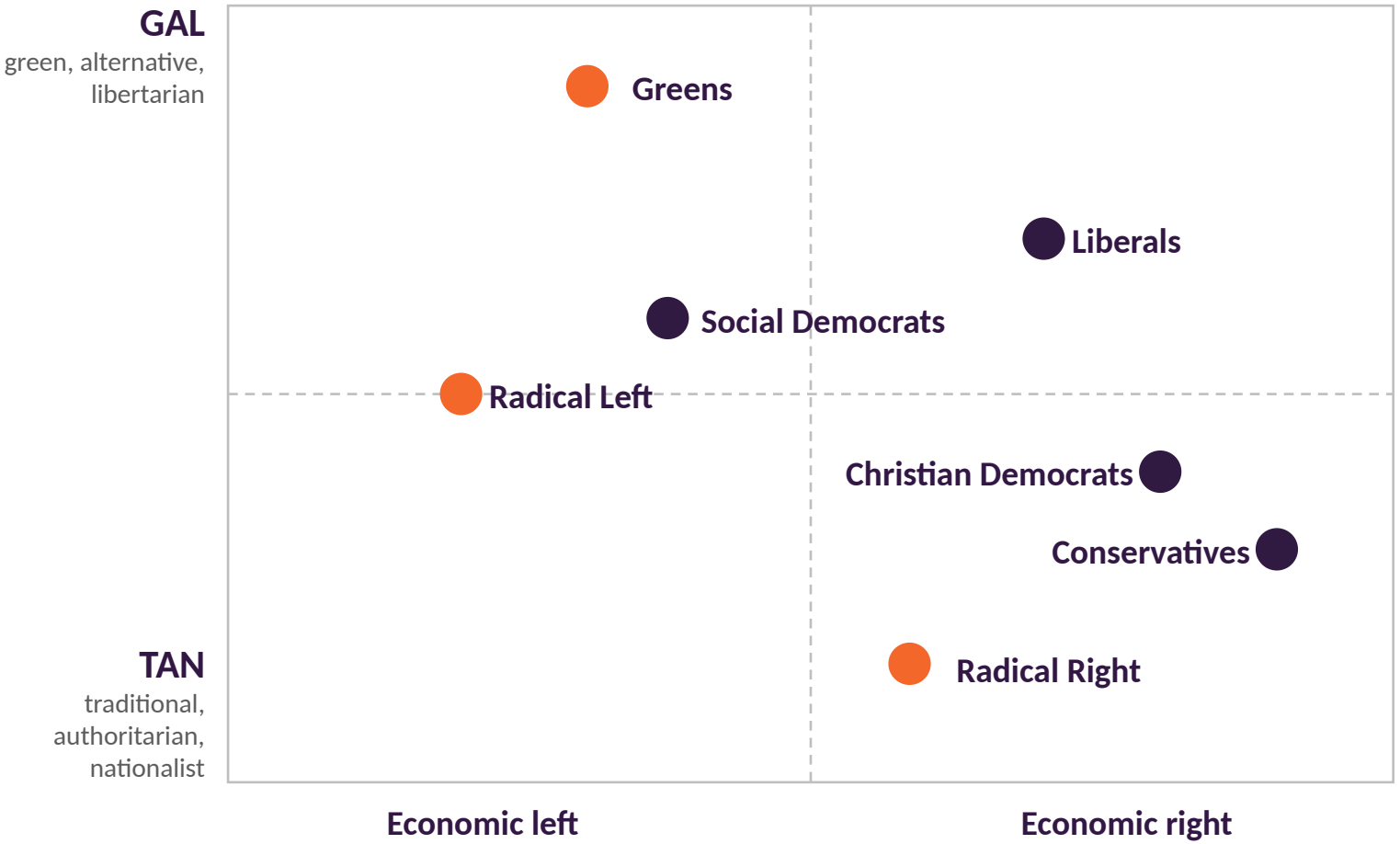


## PLACE

- Big cities draw graduates, the young and the jobs; towns and the countryside lose them
- France's yellow vests: anger at "metropolitan Paris elites"

*Robert Ford and Will Jennings, British political scientists, 2020. Education and migration already separate the parties' voters; they expect place to matter more.*

# Two dimensions: economics and culture




**ECONOMIC: LEFT TO RIGHT**

Taxes, spending, the welfare state, the role of the market

**CULTURAL: GAL TO TAN**

Immigration, Europe, national identity, social values

*GAL–TAN is the label of Liesbet Hooghe and Gary Marks, political scientists at the University of North Carolina. Positions are my rough estimates.*

# Takeaways

- Party families are useful, but imperfect labels
  - Labour under Blair was far from the Scandinavian social democrats
  - Social liberals and right liberals differ even more
- Historically: a unified mainstream left and a fragmented mainstream right
- Mainstream parties dominated until about 2008; they have lost ground to challengers of every type since
- Two explanations today: the parties changed (Katz and Mair), and the voters changed (Ford and Jennings)